Flow

User Manual

Version 1.0 · 2026

Contents

1. What is Flow?

2. Your First Diagram — Quick Start

3. Understanding Modes

4. Navigate the Canvas

5. Place and Move Shapes

6. Add Text to a Shape

7. Draw Lines

8. Connect Shapes with Anchored Lines

9. Select, Copy, and Delete

10. Save and Export

11. Quick Reference

1. What is Flow?

Flow is a keyboard-driven diagramming application designed for efficient note-taking that seamlessly integrates text and diagrams. Inspired by Vim, it uses **modes**: the action a key performs depends on the mode you are currently in. Once you learn the modes, you can build complex diagrams quickly and precisely.

Flow renders text labels using **Typst**, a markup language that supports maths, symbols, and styled text. Completed diagrams can be exported to PDF.

> **Note**
> The status bar at the bottom of the window always shows your current mode and other useful information. If a key does not behave as expected, check the status bar to confirm your current mode. A help menu listing all key within a mode is also available at any time by pressing `` ` ``.

2. Your First Diagram — Quick Start

Follow these steps to build a simple two-shape diagram connected by an arrow. This covers the primary workflow.

Step 1 — Place two shapes

1. Open Flow. You start in **Normal mode**.
2. Press `i` to enter **Insert mode**.
3. Press `c`, to place a circle.
4. Use `h` / `j` / `k` / `l` or `↑` / `↓` / `←` / `→` to move the cursor to a different location on the canvas. Flow centres the next shape on the cursor when you place it.
5. Press `c` again to place a second circle.
6. Press `Esc` to return to Normal mode.

Step 2 — Label the first shape

1. Use `h` / `j` / `k` / `l` or `↑` / `↓` / `←` / `→` to move the cursor over the first circle.
2. Press `t` to open the label editor.
3. Press `i` inside the editor to start typing, then type your label (for example: *Start*).
4. Press `Esc` twice — once to leave insert mode in the editor, and again to compile the label and close the editor.

> **Tip**
>
> Repeat Step 2 for the second shape and label it *End*.

Step 3 — Connect the shapes with an arrow

1. Move the cursor near the first rectangle in Normal mode.
2. Press `A` (capital A) to enter **Anchor-Line mode**. Anchor dots appear on all shapes.
3. Use `h` / `j` / `k` / `l` or `↑` / `↓` / `←` / `→` to navigate to the anchor dot on the right side of the first circle.
4. Press `Space` to attach the line to that anchor.
5. Navigate to the anchor dot on the left side of the second circle and press `Space` to finish the line.
6. Press `e` to add an arrowhead at the end.
7. Press `Esc` to return to Normal mode.

> **Important**
>
> When you move a shape that has an anchored line attached, the line updates automatically to follow the shape.

Step 4 — Add a title below the diagram

1. Press `i` to enter Insert mode.
2. Use `h` / `j` / `k` / `l` or `↑` / `↓` / `←` / `→` to move the cursor below the diagram.
3. Press `t` to place a text box.
4. Type "Simple Flowchart" or your desired title.
5. Press `Esc` twice — once to leave insert mode in the editor, and again to compile the label and close the editor.

Step 5 — Move shapes in Visual mode

1. Press `v` to enter Visual mode.
2. For individual selection: Move the cursor over a shape and press `Space` to select it.
3. For box select (select all): Press `V` (capital V) to enter **Visual-Block mode** and use the movement keys to draw a selection box around multiple shapes. Press `Space` to remove and start a new selection if needed.
4. Use `Shift`+`h/j/k/l` or `Shift`+`↑/↓/←/→` to move the selected shapes.
5. Press `Esc` to deselect and return to Normal mode.

> **Tip**
> You can also use `Ctrl`+`a` to select all shapes at once, then move them together. Selected shapes can also be deleted with `d` or copied with `y` (then pasted in normal mode with `p`).

Step 6 — Save

1. Press `Ctrl`+`e` to export and save your diagram.

3. Understanding Modes

Every key in Flow behaves differently depending on the active mode. Press `Esc` at any time to return to Normal mode and cancel the current action.

Mode	How to enter	What you can do
Normal	`Esc` from any mode	Move the cursor, navigate through shapes, issue commands
Insert	`i` in Normal	Place new shapes on the canvas
Visual	`v` in Normal or Visual-Block	Select shapes to move, copy, or delete
Visual-Block	`V` in Normal or Visual	Select multiple shapes with a selection box
Line	`a` in Normal or Anchor-Line	Draw a free multi-point line
Anchor-Line	`A` in Normal or Line	Draw a line anchored to shape connection points
Text	`t` near a shape	Edit the shape's label in the Typst editor
Auto-Link Insert	`I` in Normal	Place a new shape and auto-connect it to the previous shape

> **Note**
> The mode name in the status bar changes every time you switch modes. If a key does not behave as expected, check the status bar to confirm your current mode. A help menu listing all key bindings within a mode is also available at any time by pressing `` ` ``.

4. Navigate the Canvas

Move the cursor

In Normal mode, a cursor marks your current position on the canvas. Use these keys to move it.

Key	Action
`h`, `←`	Move cursor left (10 px)
`j`, `↓`	Move cursor down (10 px)
`k`, `↑`	Move cursor up (10 px)
`l`, `→`	Move cursor right (10 px)
`Ctrl`+`h/j/k/l` or `Ctrl`+`←/↓/↑/→`	Move cursor fast (50 px)

Cycle through shapes

Key	Action
`n`	Jump to the next shape
`N`	Jump to the previous shape
`M`	Move cursor to the centre of the screen
`z` `z`	Scroll the viewport to centre on the cursor
`g` `g`	Move cursor and viewport to centre of the initial screen

Pan the viewport

Key	Action
`Ctrl`+`u`	Scroll viewport up
`Ctrl`+`d`	Scroll viewport down
`Ctrl`+`,`	Scroll viewport left
`Ctrl`+`.`	Scroll viewport right

5. Place and Move Shapes

Place a shape

1. Press `i` to enter Insert mode.
2. Press the key for the shape you want (`c` for circle, `r` for rectangle, etc).
3. Move the cursor to where you want to place it. Flow centres the shape on the cursor when it is placed.
4. Press `Esc` when you are done placing shapes.

Key	Shape
`r`	Rectangle
`s`	Square
`c`	Circle
`t`	Text box

Move a shape

1. Press `v` to enter Visual mode.
2. Move the cursor over the shape and press `Space` to select it.
3. Use `Shift`+`h/j/k/l` or `Shift`+`←/↓/↑/→` to nudge the shape (10 px per press).
4. Use `Ctrl`+`Shift`+`h/j/k/l` or `Ctrl`+`Shift`+`←/↓/↑/→` for larger moves (50 px per press).
5. Press `Esc` to deselect and return to Normal mode.

Delete a shape

1. Press `v` to enter Visual mode.
2. Move the cursor over the shape and press `Space` to select it.
3. Press `d` to delete the selection.

> **Warning**
> Deleting a shape also removes all lines connected to it. Press `u` immediately to undo if this was not intended.

6. Add Text to a Shape

Every shape can carry a label. Labels are written in **Typst** markup and rendered as an image on the canvas. You do not need to know Typst to write plain text — type normally and Flow renders it as-is.

Edit a label

1. Move the cursor near the shape in Normal mode.
2. Press `t`. A text editor opens on the nearest shape.
3. Press `i` to start typing.
4. Type your text.
5. Press `Esc` to stop typing, then press `Esc` again to compile and close the editor.

> **Note**
> The label editor uses Vim key bindings. Press `i` before you begin typing — you start in the editor's Normal mode, not Insert mode.

Typst markup — common formatting

Markup you type	Result on canvas
`*bold text*`	Bold text
`_italic text_`	Italic text
`$ x^2 + y^2 $`	Inline maths: $x^2 + y^2$
`#sym.arrow.r`	Right arrow symbol →
(blank line between paragraphs)	New paragraph

> **Tip**
> If you only need plain text with no special formatting, simply type your text. No markup is required.

7. Draw Lines

A line in Flow is a polyline: a series of straight segments connected at vertices. You place each vertex with `Space`.

Draw a free line

1. Press `a` in Normal mode to enter Line mode.
2. Move the cursor to where you want the first vertex.
3. Press `Space` to place the vertex.
4. Move the cursor and press `Space` again to add more vertices.
5. Press `Esc` to finish the line and return to Normal mode.

Add arrowheads

While drawing — at any point before pressing `Esc` — press `e` to cycle through arrowhead states:

State	Description
No arrowheads	Plain line (default)
End arrowhead	Arrow at the last point
Both arrowheads	Arrows at both ends
Start arrowhead	Arrow at the first point only

Press `e` again to cycle back to no arrowheads.

8. Connect Shapes with Anchored Lines

An anchored line is attached to a specific connection point (anchor) on a shape. When you move the shape, the line follows it automatically.

Anchor points

Each shape displays its anchor points as small dots when you are in Anchor-Line mode. Use `h` / `j` / `k` / `l` to navigate between them.

Draw an anchored line between two shapes

1. In Normal mode, press `A` to enter **Anchor-Line mode**. All anchor dots of each shape appear.
2. Use `h` / `j` / `k` / `l` or `←` / `↓` / `↑` / `→` to move to the anchor where you want the line to start.
3. Press `Space` to attach the line start to that anchor.
4. Navigate to the desired anchor on the target shape.
5. Press `Space` to attach the line end and complete the connection.
6. Press `Esc` to return to Normal mode.

> **Tip**
> Press `e` at any point while drawing to cycle arrowhead states on the line.

Auto-Link Insert mode

Auto-Link Insert mode places a new shape and connects it to the previous shape automatically:

1. In Normal mode, press `I` (capital I) to enter Auto-Link Insert mode.
2. Press a shape key to insert a desired shape (`r`, `s`, `c`, or `t`).
3. Move the cursor to the desired location on the canvas.
4. Press a shape key to insert another shape. Flow places the shape and draws a connecting line from the previous shape.
5. Each subsequent shape you place connects to the one before it, forming a chain.
6. Press `Esc` to finish.

9. Select, Copy, and Delete

Select shapes

1. Press `v` in Normal mode to enter Visual mode.
2. Move the cursor over a shape and press `Space` to toggle its selection.
3. To select all shapes at once, press `Ctrl`+`a`.
4. Press `Esc` to deselect and return to Normal mode.

Copy and paste

Keys	Action
`y` (in Visual mode)	Copy (yank) the selected shapes
`p` (in Normal mode)	Paste copied shapes at the cursor position

Delete

Keys	Action
`d` (in Visual mode)	Delete all selected shapes

Undo and redo

Keys	Action
`u`	Undo the last action
`r`	Redo

10. Export

Export to PDF

1. Press `Ctrl`+`e` to export to PDF.
2. Choose a destination in the save dialog.

Flow renders all shapes and labels — including Typst maths and symbols — into the PDF.

Import a PDF slide

1. In Normal mode, press `f` to import a PDF file as a slide placeholder on the canvas.

11. Quick Reference

All modes

Keys	Action
`h` / `j` / `k` / `l` or `Arrow Keys`	Move cursor left / down / up / right (10 px)
`Ctrl`+`h/j/k/l` or `Ctrl`+`Arrow Keys`	Move cursor fast (50 px)
`` ` ``	Open the help menu for the current mode, listing all key bindings

Normal mode

Keys	Action
`n` / `N`	Jump to next / previous shape
`i`	Enter Insert mode (place shapes)
`v`	Enter Visual mode (select shapes)
`a`	Enter Line mode (free line)
`A`	Enter Anchor-Line mode
`I`	Enter Auto-Link Insert mode
`t`	Open label editor on nearest shape
`p`	Paste
`u`	Undo
`r`	Redo
`f`	Import PDF
`Ctrl`+`e`	Export to PDF
`Esc`	Return to Normal mode from any other mode

Insert mode

Keys	Action
`r`	Place rectangle
`s`	Place square
`c`	Place circle

`t`	Place text box
`Esc`	Return to Normal mode

Visual mode

Keys	Action
`Space`	Toggle selection on shape at cursor
`Ctrl` + `a`	Select all shapes
`Shift` + `h/j/k/l` or `Shift` + `Arrow Keys`	Move selected shapes (10 px)
`Ctrl` + `Shift` + `h/j/k/l` or `Ctrl` + `Shift` + `Arrow Keys`	Move selected shapes (50 px)
`y`	Copy (yank) selection
`d`	Delete selection
`p`	Paste copied shapes at cursor position
`V`	Enter Visual-Block mode (box select)
`Esc`	Deselect and return to Normal mode

Visual-Block mode

Keys	Action
`h/j/k/l` or `Arrow Keys`	Expand selection box left / down / up / right
`Space`	Toggle selection box
`y`	Copy (yank) selection
`d`	Delete selection
`p`	Paste copied shapes at cursor position
`Ctrl` + `a`	Select all shapes
`v`	Enter Visual mode (select shapes individually)
`Esc`	Deselect and return to Normal mode

Line mode

Keys / Action	Effect
`h` / `j` / `k` / `l`	Move cursor

`Space`	Place vertex at cursor position
`e`	Cycle arrowhead state (none → end → both → start)
`Esc`	Finish line and return to Normal mode

Anchor-Line mode

Keys / Action	Effect
`h` / `j` / `k` / `l` or `Arrow Keys`	Navigate between anchor points
`Space`	Attach line to current anchor point
`e`	Cycle arrowhead state
`Esc`	Finish line and return to Normal mode

Text mode (label editor)

Keys	Action
`i`	Start typing (enter editor Insert mode)
`Esc`	Stop typing (return to editor Normal mode)
`Esc` (from editor Normal)	Compile label and close editor

Auto-Link Insert mode

Keys	Action
`r`	Place rectangle and connect to previous shape
`s`	Place square and connect to previous shape
`c`	Place circle and connect to previous shape
`t`	Place text box and connect to previous shape
`Esc`	Finish and return to Normal mode

Viewport

Keys	Action
`Ctrl`+`u`	Scroll viewport up
`Ctrl`+`d`	Scroll viewport down
`Ctrl`+`,`	Scroll viewport left
`Ctrl`+`.`	Scroll viewport right
`M`	Move cursor to screen centre

z z	Centre viewport on cursor
g g	Move cursor and viewport to initial screen centre